

THE MYSTERIES OF
HARRIS BURDICK



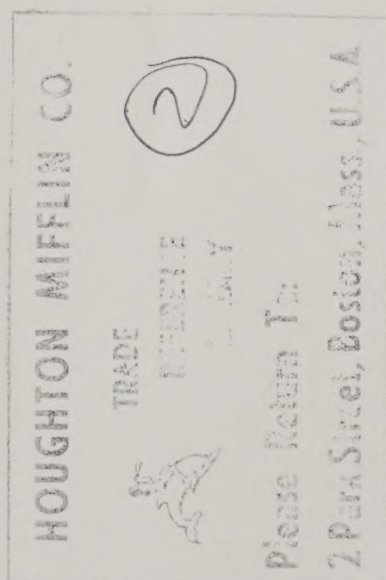
CHRIS VAN ALLSBURG

THE MYSTERIES OF HARRIS BURDICK

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When Chris Van Allsburg was invited to the home of Peter Wenders, he discovered fourteen drawings that were, like pieces of a picture puzzle, clues to larger pictures. But the puzzles, the mysteries, presented by these drawings, are not what we are used to. They are not solved for us, as in the final pages of a book or a film's last reel. The solutions to these mysteries lie in a place at once closer at hand, yet far more remote. They lie in our imagination.

For those who have thought of themselves as unimaginative, this book will prove the opposite. Even the most reluctant imagination, when confronted by these drawings, will not be able to resist solving the mysteries of Harris Burdick.



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HOUGHTON MIFFLIN COMPANY

BOSTON 1984

With thanks to
Peter Wenders

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The mysteries of Harris Burdick.

Summary: Presents a series of loosely related drawings each accompanied by a title and a caption which the reader may use to make up his or her own story.

1. Plot-your-own stories. 2. Children's stories, American. [1. Mystery and detective stories. 2. Plot-your-own stories] I. Title.

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INTRODUCTION

I first saw the drawings in this book a year ago, in the home of a man named Peter Wenders. Though Mr. Wenders is retired now, he once worked for a children's book publisher, choosing the stories and pictures that would be turned into books.

Thirty years ago a man called at Peter Wenders's office, introducing himself as Harris Burdick. Mr. Burdick explained that he had written fourteen stories and had drawn many pictures for each one. He'd brought with him just one drawing from each story, to see if Wenders liked his work.

Peter Wenders was fascinated by the drawings. He told Burdick he would like to read the stories that went with them as soon as possible. The artist agreed to bring the stories the next morning. He left the fourteen drawings with Wenders. But he did not return the next day. Or the day after that. Harris Burdick was never heard from again. Over the years, Wenders tried to find out who Burdick was and what had happened to him, but he discovered nothing. To this day Harris Burdick remains a complete mystery.

His disappearance is not the only mystery left behind. What were the stories that went with these drawings? There are some clues. Burdick had written a title and caption for each picture. When I told Peter Wenders how difficult it was to look at the drawings and their captions without imagining a story, he smiled and left the room. He returned with a dust-covered cardboard box. Inside were dozens of stories, all inspired by the Burdick drawings. They'd been written years ago by Wenders's children and their friends.

I spent the rest of my visit reading these stories. They were remarkable, some bizarre, some funny, some downright scary. In the hope that other children will be inspired by them, the Burdick drawings are reproduced here for the first time.

Chris Van Allsburg
Providence, Rhode Island

ARCHIE SMITH, BOY WONDER

A tiny voice asked, "Is he the one?"



UNDER THE RUG

Two weeks passed and it happened again.



A STRANGE DAY IN JULY

*He threw with all his might, but the
third stone came skipping back.*



MISSING IN VENICE

*Even with her mighty engines in reverse,
the ocean liner was pulled further and
further into the canal.*



ANOTHER PLACE, ANOTHER TIME

If there was an answer, he'd find it there.



UNINVITED GUESTS

*His heart was pounding.
He was sure he had seen the doorknob turn.*



THE HARP

So it's true he thought, it's really true.



MR. LINDEN'S LIBRARY

He had warned her about the book.

Now it was too late.



THE SEVEN CHAIRS

The fifth one ended up in France.



THE THIRD-FLOOR BEDROOM

*It all began when someone left
the window open.*



JUST DESERT

*She lowered the knife and
it grew even brighter.*



CAPTAIN TORY

*He swung his lantern
three times and slowly the schooner appeared.*



OSCAR AND ALPHONSE

*She knew it was time to send them back.
The caterpillars softly wiggled in her hand,
spelling out "goodbye."*



THE HOUSE ON MAPLE STREET

It was a perfect lift-off.



BOSTON PUBLIC LIBRARY



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THE GARDEN OF ABDUL GASAZI

"This is without question one of the best — and most original — picture books in years."
— *New York Times Book Review*

"Artist Van Allsburg's debut is this work of singular beauty and mystery. . . . A prize for all ages." — *Publishers Weekly*

JUMANJI

"A beautiful simplicity of design, balance, texture, and a subtle intelligence beyond the call of illustration."
— *New York Times Book Review*

"Consummate draftsmanship creates stunning velvet-flat, black-and-white scenes that are endlessly fascinating."
— *Booklist* starred review

BEN'S DREAM

"[Van Allsburg's] skill in the lost art and subtle fine points of sculptural line drawing is nothing less than remarkable."
— *Art Express Magazine*

"A visual tour de force." — *Horn Book*

THE WRECK OF THE ZEPHYR

"There is a new richness of color in *The Wreck of the Zephyr*, and some of the images of flight are worthy of Magritte himself. But the text is as spare, as sober and telling as ever. It would be difficult to imagine a better book of its kind." — *New York Times Book Review*

"The full-color pastel drawings are the work of a master: stunning, luminescent and conveying a sense of the mystical and magical."
— *Publishers Weekly*

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